

2026 NCAA Tournament - Monte Carlo Optimal Bracket

Maximum-likelihood picks from 50,000 simulations | Green = predicted winner | Gold = Final Four | % = champ probability

East Region							
Round of 64	Round of 32	Sweet 16	Elite 8	Final Four			
(1) Duke	(1) Duke	(1) Duke	(1) Duke	(1) Duke [37.9%]			
(16) Siena							
(8) Ohio State							
(9) Texas Christian							
(5) St. John's (NY)	(5) St. John's (NY)						
(12) Northern Iowa							
(4) Kansas							
(13) California Baptist							
(6) Louisville	(3) Michigan State						
(11) South Florida							
(3) Michigan State							
(14) North Dakota State							
(7) UCLA	(2) Connecticut	(2) Connecticut					
(10) Central Florida(UCF)							
(2) Connecticut							
(15) Furman							

West Region				
Round of 64	Round of 32	Sweet 16	Elite 8	Final Four
(1) Florida	(9) Iowa	(9) Iowa	(3) Illinois	(3) Illinois [5.8%]
(16) Lehigh				
(8) Clemson				
(9) Iowa				
(5) Vanderbilt	(5) Vanderbilt			
(12) Mcneese State				
(4) Nebraska				
(13) Troy St.				
(6) North Carolina	(3) Illinois	(3) Illinois		
(11) Virginia Commonwealth				
(3) Illinois				
(14) Pennsylvania				
(7) Saint Mary's (CA)	(2) Houston			
(10) Texas A&M				
(2) Houston				
(15) Idaho				

South Region				
Round of 64	Round of 32	Sweet 16	Elite 8	Final Four
(1) Michigan	(1) Michigan	(1) Michigan	(1) Michigan	(1) Michigan [12.9%]
(16) Maryland-Baltimore Co...				
(8) Georgia				
(9) Saint Louis	(4) Alabama			
(5) Texas Tech				
(12) Akron				
(4) Alabama	(3) Virginia			
(13) Hofstra				
(6) Tennessee				
(11) Miami (OHIO)	(2) Iowa State			
(3) Virginia				
(14) Wright State				
(7) Kentucky	(2) Iowa State			
(10) Santa Clara				
(2) Iowa State				
(15) Tennessee State				

Midwest Region				
Round of 64	Round of 32	Sweet 16	Elite 8	Final Four
(1) Arizona	(1) Arizona	(1) Arizona	(1) Arizona	(1) Arizona [12.1%]
(16) Long Island University				
(8) Villanova				
(9) Utah State	(4) Arkansas			
(5) Wisconsin				
(12) High Point				
(4) Arkansas				
(13) Hawai'i	(3) Gonzaga			
(6) Brigham Young				
(11) Texas				
(3) Gonzaga				
(14) Kennesaw State	(2) Purdue			
(7) Miami - Florida				
(10) Missouri				
(2) Purdue				
(15) Queens (NC)				

Final Four & Championship

Semifinal 1 (East vs West)	Semifinal 2 (South vs Midwest)	NATIONAL CHAMPION
(1) Duke [37.9%]	(1) Michigan [12.9%]	(1) Duke [37.9%]

Championship Probability Leaderboard (Top 15)

Rank	Team	Seed	R32%	Sweet16%	Elite8%	Final4%	Champ%
1	Duke	1	99.2	91.3	83.2	72.1	37.9
2	Michigan	1	99.1	82.7	63.7	43.6	12.9
3	Arizona	1	99.2	85.0	60.5	38.2	12.1
4	Purdue	2	96.0	81.8	58.4	31.9	8.6
5	Iowa State	2	96.1	81.6	62.7	32.5	6.7
6	Illinois	3	92.3	78.0	53.0	31.8	5.8
7	Florida	1	99.2	75.8	50.2	28.2	4.3
8	Arkansas	4	87.8	66.0	27.4	12.3	2.0
9	Vanderbilt	5	77.4	55.7	28.1	13.9	1.6
10	Houston	2	95.8	69.1	32.0	15.4	1.6
11	Gonzaga	3	91.0	65.1	27.2	11.1	1.5
12	Connecticut	2	95.7	70.5	40.1	9.4	1.2
13	Alabama	4	86.2	57.7	20.0	9.3	1.0
14	Michigan State	3	90.0	52.6	27.4	6.2	0.7
15	Louisville	6	70.9	38.8	20.6	4.3	0.4